



“If India carries out a surgical attack, we will strike right back”

REUBEN SINGH

General Pervez Musharraf, former President of Pakistan, discusses burning issues that confront India and Pakistan in an exclusive interview with INDIA TODAY Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie and Managing Editor Raj Chengappa during his recent visit to New Delhi. Excerpts:

Q. General Musharraf, you projected yourself as a messenger of peace at the India Today Conclave and said that the centrality of Kashmir is the most important issue. You had come close to a deal in your talks with the Manmohan Singh Government. What was the deal?

A. There were certain parameters like graduated demilitarisation in Kashmir, giving self-governance, having some kind of joint oversight and then an agreement to make the Line of Control (LoC) irrelevant through maximum people-to-people and trade interaction. These were the elements that we were trying to include in the package.

Q. So how close were you to a deal?

A. We were close. The broad parameters were to be the same as I mentioned. The issue was the LoC and what to do

about it. India could not accept any change in its status. Pakistan considered the LoC the problem. How could the dispute be the solution? Therefore the solution lay in making it irrelevant. That is the conclusion we had reached in terms of how to make it irrelevant and that we ought to do it with sincerity. All that was left was the drafting of the parameters of the agreement and the boldness to sign it.

Q. Why didn't it happen then?

A. We had requested Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to visit Pakistan and that it shouldn't be aimless when he does. It would fall flat if we didn't sign any agreement whether it was Siachen, Sir Creek or Kashmir, or all three; we must move forward. I think he had agreed with me on that. This was in 2007. He could have come. But yes, there was some turmoil in Pakistan; the lawyers' issue, which was politicised to a degree.

Q. Coming back to making the border irrelevant. Is that an acceptable solution to India, which wants to make the LoC the international border?

A. I don't think anyone in Pakistan is going to accept it as